



SHOW ME THE MONEY

Unlocking Incentives That Make Clean Energy Happen
Featured Panel Summary | Westchester Clean Energy Action Conference

This featured panel put affordability at the center of the clean energy conversation, moving from the financial incentives that already exist in Westchester County, to the obstacles that keep them from being used, to the tools that could close the gap. Representatives from county government, a city development office, the state's public power authority, and the local utility made the case that the money is largely already on the table; what is missing is awareness, coordination, and a regulatory environment that lets private capital underwrite these projects on its own.

SESSION PARTICIPANTS

Moderator **Eon S. Nichols, Esq.**
Cuddy & Feder LLP

Adam Salgado Commissioner of Development
City of New Rochelle

Dimitris Vantzis Department Manager
Con Edison

Joan McDonald Deputy County Executive
Westchester County

Alana Appenzeller Director, Key Account Mgmt.
New York Power Authority

1. THE MONEY IS ALREADY ON THE TABLE

The panel opened by inventorying what is available right now. Westchester County has no incentive written specifically for clean energy, but its IDA and Local Development Corporation offer PILOTs, sales tax exemptions on construction and supply materials, and mortgage recording tax exemptions for any company building or rehabilitating in the county, tools clean energy companies have used, as when Birnie Bus relocated to the Town of Cortlandt and built a servicing facility for New York State's 2027 electric bus mandate. New Rochelle layers its own IDA, C-PACE financing, and a Green NR sustainability platform on top. NYPA's Recharge New York program delivers low-cost hydropower from Niagara Falls and the St. Lawrence under contracts of up to seven years in exchange for job and investment commitments. And Con Edison alone runs roughly three-quarters of a billion dollars a year in customer programs, often covering 50% of project costs and, in areas targeting aging gas infrastructure, up to 100%.

"We have a programmatic budget of about three-quarters of a billion dollars each year that we make available to our customers."

Dimitris Vantzis, Con Edison

2. THE BIGGEST MISSED OPPORTUNITY IS GETTING PAID TO USE LESS

Asked to name the single most underutilized incentive, Con Edison pointed to demand response and managed EV charging: programs that pay customers to reduce load at peak times or charge at night. Enrollment is already substantial (roughly 100,000 customers and about a gigawatt of enrolled capacity in demand response; about 30% of electric vehicles in the service territory on managed charging, which leads the nation) but that still leaves 70% of EVs unenrolled. The panel's diagnosis was that these programs sound complex or technical, or simply come up too late in the planning process. Westchester County has been proving the value since 2018: it was one of the first counties to enroll in demand response, and has since returned more than \$2 million to its general fund.

"These programs essentially put money into customers' pockets without having to even build a project."

Dimitris Vantzis, Con Edison

3. THE INCENTIVES ARE MEANT TO STACK

A persistent misconception the panel wanted to kill: that using one program locks you out of another. The intended architecture is layered: NYPA financing or C-PACE to fund a project, federal technology incentives on the equipment, and utility operating incentives that reward the grid benefits afterward. Both NYPA and Con Edison said their teams actively work to optimize across the full stack. The honest caveat came from the utility side: there is not yet a fully integrated stack a customer can simply access. Timing inconsistencies, overlapping scope, and complicated co-enrollment rules remain real, and federal programs change fast enough that keeping program design aligned with them is a moving target.

"These programs are meant to work together, to be stacked together. Both NYPA and Con Ed, when you're working with us, we're looking to optimize all the incentives out there."

Alana Appenzeller, New York Power Authority

4. WHERE PROJECTS DIE: HOME RULE, MORATORIUMS, AND THE QUEUE

The moderator framed the hindrances with two stories: a homeowner who wants solar and EV charging but finds the market so confusing and robocall-saturated that he opts out entirely, and a national clean energy client that brought a project to a long-vacant Westchester parcel, got a quarter of the way through the approval process, and was stopped by a moratorium, then took the investment elsewhere. New York's strong home-rule tradition means the county can convene and incentivize but cannot override local land use. Layered on top is interconnection: the statewide queue is years deep, the eventual costs are unpredictable, and enough projects die waiting that the panel warned capital is beginning to leave for faster markets.

"You're waiting years, and then the costs that come from it are really astonishing, and I think that's what really hinders a lot of projects from moving forward."

Alana Appenzeller, New York Power Authority

5. FEAR, NOT OPPOSITION, IS WHAT LOCAL GOVERNMENT IS ACTUALLY FIGHTING

On battery storage specifically, the panel rejected the idea that communities are ideologically opposed. What they are is afraid, and the fear is fed by EV fire coverage (New Rochelle has had a few) rather than by the chemistry actually used in grid-scale and community-scale storage, which is different, more modular, and easier to suppress. The answer offered was capability plus education: a fire department

equipped and trained for lithium fires, parking garages and new developments evaluated for firefighter access, an EV master plan to generate information the city can hand its constituents, and utilities and authorities brought in as credible messengers.

"I think at the end of the day, that's what we're kind of climbing over, is a hill of resistance that's founded in fear."

Adam Salgado, City of New Rochelle

6. FROM SUBSIDY TO STANDARD PRACTICE

The most pointed argument of the session was that incentives alone will never be enough, because they depend on politics and appropriations that change with every administration. The durable move is to write sustainability into the rules and the underwriting. New Rochelle requires LEED ND Silver as a zoning baseline, is adding a points-based sustainability checklist to its form-based code that earns relief on developer fees, and ties green investment to public-realm improvements so residents can see what they are getting. Westchester County has been issuing green bonds since 2022 (the first county in the state to do so, targeting \$20–30 million a year), pays half the cost of municipal EV charging stations, and budgeted \$10 million this year for its Landlord Tenant Assistance Program for energy upgrades in small buildings. The panel also pointed to New Rochelle's planned net-zero transit center solar array and the county's three years of quiet work on the Propel transmission line as examples of what patient, unglamorous groundwork produces.

"While incentives are great, they rely on politics and appropriations at all levels of government. But if we can't build the incentives into the financing stacks of these developments, it's never really gonna be sustainable."

Adam Salgado, City of New Rochelle

7. THE FIRST STEP IS A CONVERSATION

Every panelist converged on the same practical advice: stop waiting for the perfect plan and start talking to the people whose job it is to help. IDAs are underutilized and free to consult. Con Edison and NYPA both offer energy assessments, typically a site visit at little or no cost, that routinely surface cheap, fast-payback measures like lighting upgrades in warehouses and offices. Con Edison maintains a vetted network of participating contractors and about three dozen demand-response aggregators who will walk a customer through enrollment, and simple entry points exist for residential customers too, such as enrolling a smart thermostat or an EV through the manufacturer's app. Options like community solar and power purchase agreements also let customers participate without a large upfront investment.

"It takes time to get things built in this county and this state and these municipalities, and you have to do your homework to see what programs are out there for money, for incentives, work with us on the regulatory environment, and then do your homework."

Joan McDonald, Westchester County

KEY TAKEAWAYS

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The incentives already exist. County and city IDAs offer PILOTs and sales/mortgage tax exemptions, NYPA offers low-cost hydropower through Recharge New York, and Con Edison runs roughly \$750 million a year in customer programs.

02	The most underutilized money requires no project at all. Demand response and managed EV charging pay customers to shift or reduce load; 70% of EVs in Con Edison's territory are still not enrolled.
03	Programs are designed to stack. Working with NYPA does not disqualify you from Con Edison, but a fully integrated, one-stop incentive stack does not yet exist, and co-enrollment rules remain complicated.
04	Home rule and moratoriums are where projects die locally. One national client abandoned a Westchester site mid-process and moved the investment out of the county.
05	Interconnection is the statewide bottleneck. Multi-year queues and unpredictable costs are pushing capital toward faster markets.
06	Community resistance to battery storage is fear, not ideology. Equipped fire departments, EV master plans, and credible messengers from the utilities are the tools that work.
07	Incentives depend on politics; codes and underwriting do not. Zoning baselines, points-based sustainability checklists, green bonds, and normalized private financing are what make clean energy durable at scale.
08	Start with a conversation. Free or near-free energy assessments, participating contractors, and demand-response aggregators exist specifically to get customers from interest to enrollment.